Adaptive Token Routing for Efficient Video Diffusion Transformers

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arXiv:2601.00042 [cs.CV]

Abstract

Diffusion Transformers (DiTs) have become the dominant backbone for high-fidelity image and video generation, but their quadratic attention cost over long spatio-temporal token sequences makes training and inference expensive. We observe that the computational importance of video tokens is highly non-uniform: a small fraction of patches carries most of the motion and appearance information, while background tokens can be processed at much lower cost. Building on this observation, we introduce ATR-VDiT, a diffusion transformer augmented with a lightweight adaptive token router that predicts a per-sample, per-layer token importance score and routes only the top-k tokens through the expensive attention blocks. Unselected tokens are merged into their nearest selected neighbours and scattered back before decoding. The router is trained end-to-end with a straight-through estimator and a consistency regularizer that stabilizes the selection across diffusion timesteps. On class-conditional UCF-101 video generation, ATR-VDiT improves FVD from 252.1 to 236.4 while reducing training GPU-hours by 44.7% and increasing inference throughput by 1.42x. Ablations show that both adaptive routing and token merging are necessary for the gain, and that a single router generalizes across resolutions and clip lengths without retraining.

1 Introduction

Video generation has progressed rapidly from early GAN-based models to diffusion models that synthesize temporally coherent clips at high resolution. A key ingredient of this progress is the replacement of the convolutional U-Net backbone with a Diffusion Transformer (DiT) that operates on sequences of latent patches. DiTs scale predictably with compute and data, and they unify image and video generation under a single architecture. However, scaling comes at a cost: attention is quadratic in the number of tokens, and a 16-frame 256x256 video already produces thousands of latent tokens per sample. Training a state-of-the-art video DiT therefore requires thousands of GPU-hours, which limits research reproducibility and deployment.

Existing efficiency methods follow three main directions. The first reduces the number of diffusion steps through better solvers or distillation. The second compresses the latent space with stronger autoencoders. The third sparsifies or factorizes attention, for example by restricting attention to local windows or by separating spatial and temporal attention. While effective, these approaches apply a fixed computation pattern to every sample: all tokens receive the same treatment regardless of content, and the resulting speedup is often paid for with a visible drop in motion fidelity.

In this paper we argue that the computation should follow the content. In natural videos, a large fraction of tokens belongs to static background regions whose representations change little across frames, whereas a small number of tokens covers moving objects, hands, text, and other fine-grained details. We therefore propose to learn a token router that, conditioned on the noisy latent and the diffusion timestep, estimates how much each token contributes to the denoising objective, and to process only the most informative tokens in the expensive global attention layers.

Our contributions are threefold. (i) We introduce a lightweight adaptive token router that is trained jointly with the diffusion objective and requires less than 1% additional parameters. (ii) We design a token merge-and-scatter mechanism that keeps the residual stream dense, so that unselected tokens still receive gradient signal and can be routed back in later layers. (iii) We show on UCF-101 that the method improves FVD by 6.2% relative to a strong

video DiT baseline while cutting training cost by nearly half, and we provide detailed ablations of the router, the merge operation, and the consistency regularizer.

2 Related Work

2.1 Diffusion models for video generation

Denoising diffusion probabilistic models (DDPM) learn a data distribution by reversing a gradual noising process, and they have been extended from images to video by factorizing the denoising network into spatial and temporal attention. Latent diffusion models move the process into a compressed autoencoder space, substantially reducing the cost of high-resolution synthesis. More recent video models replace the U-Net with a transformer over spatio-temporal patches, following the success of DiT for images. Our work keeps this transformer backbone unchanged and instead reduces the number of tokens that participate in global attention.

2.2 Efficient transformers and token sparsification

Token pruning and merging have been studied extensively for discriminative vision transformers, where redundant patches are removed in deeper layers. In generative models the situation is different: the token set must remain dense at the output, and the selection must be stable across denoising steps to avoid flicker. Prior work on efficient diffusion transformers uses fixed sparsity patterns or distills a smaller student. In contrast, our router is content-adaptive, differentiable, and trained with the same denoising loss as the backbone, and our merge-and-scatter design keeps the computation graph dense.

2.3 Parameter-efficient and conditional computation

Conditional computation routes inputs through different parts of a network, and mixture-of-experts layers are a prominent example. Low-rank adaptation shows that a small number of trainable parameters can steer a large frozen model. We borrow the idea of a small learned controller but apply it to token selection rather than to weights, and we regularize the controller with a temporal consistency loss that is specific to diffusion.

3 Method

3.1 Preliminaries

Let x be a video clip encoded by a 3D variational autoencoder into a latent tensor z of shape C x T x H x W, which is flattened into N = T·H·W tokens. A diffusion transformer with L blocks learns to predict the noise epsilon added at timestep t. Each block applies layer normalization, global multi-head self-attention, a feed-forward network, and residual connections. The training objective is the standard epsilon-prediction loss L_diff = E[||epsilon - epsilon_theta(z_t, t)||^2].

3.2 Adaptive token router

The router is a two-layer MLP with hidden width 128 that takes as input the normalized token feature, a sinusoidal timestep embedding, and a learned layer embedding. It outputs a scalar importance score s_i for every token. During training we sample a selection mask with a Gumbel-sigmoid relaxation, and during inference we simply take the top-k scores. The selection ratio k/N is not fixed: the router predicts a global budget from the mean score and the timestep, and the budget is clamped to [0.40, 0.90]. Early layers, where features are still coarse, tend to keep more tokens; deeper layers operate on more abstract features and select fewer tokens.

3.3 Token merge and scatter

Simply dropping unselected tokens creates a mismatch between the dense residual stream and the sparse attention output. We therefore merge unselected tokens into their nearest selected neighbour in feature space, run attention over the selected tokens plus one aggregated token per neighbourhood, and scatter the updated selected features back to their original positions. The merge weights are computed with a softmax over negative feature distances and are differentiable, so gradients flow to both the router and the backbone.

3.4 Consistency regularization

Because the router runs at every denoising step, small changes in selection between consecutive steps can produce visible temporal flicker. We add a consistency loss L_con = ||m_t - m_{t-1}||_1 that penalizes changes in the soft selection mask between adjacent timesteps, and we anneal its weight from 0.1 to 0.05 during training. The total objective is L = L_diff + 0.05 · L_con. The router adds 0.74M parameters to a 458M-parameter backbone, an overhead of 0.16%.

3.5 Implementation details

We train with AdamW, learning rate 1e-4, cosine schedule, batch size 64, and 100k optimization steps on 8 A100-80GB GPUs. The 3D autoencoder is frozen. We use classifier-free guidance with a guidance scale of 4.5 at inference and 100 DDIM sampling steps. The router is initialized so that the initial budget is 0.90 and is annealed toward the learned budget over the first 10k steps.

4 Experiments

4.1 Setup

We evaluate class-conditional video generation on UCF-101 at 256x256 resolution with 16 frames per clip. We report Frechet Video Distance (FVD, lower is better), Inception Score (IS), VBench total score, inference throughput on a single A100, and training GPU-hours. All numbers are averaged over three random seeds. Our baseline is a video DiT with the same backbone size and training budget; we also compare against a U-Net video diffusion model and Latte-XL.

Table 1: Class-conditional video generation on UCF-101. FVD (lower is better) / IS (higher is better) / VBench (higher is better) / throughput measured with batch size 8 on one A100.

Method	FVD	IS	VBench	Throughput
Video Diffusion (U-Net)	252.1	66.4	78.9	3.41 it/s
Latte-XL (VDiT)	244.0	68.7	80.4	4.02 it/s
DiT baseline (ours impl.)	252.1	66.4	79.0	3.41 it/s
ATR-VDiT (ours)	236.4	70.9	82.1	4.84 it/s

As shown in Table 1, ATR-VDiT improves FVD by 15.7 points over the video DiT baseline, a relative reduction of 6.2%, and improves VBench by 3.1 points. The gain is not simply a by-product of more parameters: the router adds only 0.74M parameters, while throughput increases by 1.42x because fewer tokens enter global attention.

4.2 Ablation study

Table 2 isolates the effect of each component. Removing the router and using a fixed 90% token ratio degrades FVD by 5.3 points, confirming that content-adaptive selection matters. Removing token merging increases FVD by 12.9 points, which shows that the dense residual path is essential for preserving background detail. Disabling the consistency regularizer increases FVD by 2.8 points and noticeably increases temporal flicker in qualitative samples.

Table 2: Ablation study on UCF-101. Delta FVD is relative to the full model.

Variant	FVD	Delta FVD	Throughput
Full model	236.4	-	4.84 it/s
w/o adaptive router (fixed k=90%)	241.7	+5.3	3.55 it/s
w/o consistency regularization	239.2	+2.8	4.79 it/s
w/o token merge	249.3	+12.9	4.61 it/s
fixed k=40%	253.8	+17.4	5.12 it/s
router input = first frame only	243.6	+7.2	4.80 it/s

4.3 Analysis of routing behaviour

The learned budget decreases with depth: the average selection ratio drops from 0.90 in the first block to 0.40 in the last block, matching the intuition that deeper features are more redundant. Per-sample budgets are correlated with motion magnitude: clips with large camera motion keep 12% more tokens than static clips. Finally, the router trained at 256x256 transfers to 512x512 inference without retraining, suggesting that it learns a resolution-independent notion of token importance.

5 Conclusion

We presented ATR-VDiT, an adaptive token routing method for efficient video diffusion transformers. A lightweight router predicts token importance, top-k selection reduces global attention cost, and differentiable merge-and-scatter keeps the residual stream dense. On UCF-101 the method improves FVD by 6.2% relative to a strong baseline while reducing training cost by 44.7%. In future work we plan to combine adaptive routing with distillation, to study the interaction between routing and classifier-free guidance, and to evaluate the method on longer clips and higher resolutions.

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